

This wasn't exactly a swanky neighborhood in which tire disposal services run at a premium. We're talking about a musty apartment only one block from the area of town known as Crack Whore Row. And it was a *bicycle* tire, not a car tire complete with wheel and hubcap. I was pissed off that I forgot it, because I could have used it, but I didn't have the energy to fight the landlord over the charge. I wish I had, because it was completely bogus. But I didn't fight the charge, even though I now know I should have raised a stink over it.

Since then, though, I've learned a few things. Here are 20 tips for getting your security deposit back.

BEFORE YOU MOVE IN:

1. Google the leasing company, landlord's name, property name, whatever. See if you are dealing with people who are on the up and up. Check the Better Business Bureau's online business listings (BBB.org) for the leasing company's name (ask the landlord if they have a relationship with the BBB). The landlord that charged me \$75 to throw away a bicycle tire had an awful Web reputation—had I known that, I might never have rented the place to begin with.

WHEN YOU MOVE IN:

2. Read your lease carefully. Understand everything that is contained therein. Note that *leases are not set in stone*. You can actually make alterations to them—nothing ridiculous—but if you find something in the lease that you find unreasonable (like being required to give two months' notice when you plan to leave), you can alter it, cross it out, or make additions to it.
3. Your landlord *should* give you a checklist of rooms and ask you to detail the condition of each one. If they don't, make one up yourself. Notice any damage that exists already (*dings in wood, cupboards that don't close properly*). This can be extremely tedious, so make an evening of it. Invite some friends over for a few bottles of wine (or beer) and walk around the apartment, critiquing the hell out of it.
4. If you have a digital camera, take pictures of every room, every blemish.
5. When you have gathered all of this info, written and photographic, do a walk-through with the landlord and make sure that they sign off on the list. Mail them printouts of the photos and